

Round one! (Ding!)

Salamander

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PACK MY BOX WITH FIVE DOZEN LIQUOR JUGS.

THE FIVE BOXING WIZARDS JUMP QUICKLY.

Within an hour or so, I had gotten about as far as I've ever gone, which is probably about three miles, maybe four. It was a pleasant secluded area; the creek was broad and shallow there, and I could see a long way into the forest, populated with trees standing a good distance away from each other (though it got denser a bit farther in). Up ahead I could see it got narrower. I stopped for a while, walked up onto dry land—my feet had pruned up from walking so long in the water—and sort of sat around for a little while. Rested. There were birds chirping, and also crickets, though it was only about three in the afternoon. While I was leaning up against the broad trunk of the twisted old oak, I also noticed a squirrel scampering over a branch, then back where he came, then across it again. I wonder what he was up to.

After about fifteen minutes I stood up and walked back into the creek. In addition to getting narrower, it was getting quicker, as would be expected. I was pleased to note it turned into a riffle for a while, tossed back and forth from left to right by the shape of the bank. After that it got slower for a little while, but then I found myself walking into an area of deep water whizzing through a very narrow channel. My shorts got wet. I was relieved to find it upsloping after not too long. But it kept upsloping. Looking down at my feet to keep from slipping, I noticed only when I was considerably too late that the creek was jumping irresponsibly over a drop of about fifteen feet and raising a very energetic ruckus at the bottom.

I would love to report that the fall happened in slow-motion, like it always seems to in movies or books, but it didn't. I realized that I was not standing on anything, and then I had a brief moment to think, "Oh, hell," and then I hit the water. It was extraordinarily hard water, and, as I was in a bellyflop sort of position, I got the wind knocked out of me. I went under before I got a chance to figure out how to breathe, and for an amount of time I would have considered impossible in the situation—probably at least a minute, and remember I hadn't held my breath—I flailed around trying to get back up to the air. I am now very vividly acquainted with what an undercurrent is. But I found my way out of that and broke the surface and (now having remembered how

to breathe) filled up with oxygen. The first thing I was concerned with was what was in my pockets.

Anything valuable? I did a mental inventory and then a physical one. I hadn't had anything of much import to start with, *except a ten-dollar bill, which I found to my relief was still clinging to the inside of my pocket. I also still had my pencil. So on that I was all okay. Then I got a bit more concerned with how I was going to get onto land. It was at this time that I realized that the creek was still deep and fast, and I was coming up on a field of very large rocks. I treaded water to stay up on the surface and the current swept me indifferently onward. And, drawing on my expert pinball skills, I suavely rammed up on the first boulder, on the right, and pushed myself on into the middle of the current, then bounced off another one jutting out from the left, in the process making it through a worryingly tight squeeze, and then pushed myself off into the left, which was clear, by bouncing off two boulders in the right and middle. I unfortunately didn't see the boulder that was under the surface and it banged really hard into my shins. I put my hand on one to see if there was any severe damage, but in doing so stopped treading and went under. I came back up and wiped the water out of my eyes just in time to see myself crash into a huge and painfully-shaped rock on the right bank. My hands were rubbed raw from trying to cushion the impact. The rush of the water was the only sound; I went under again briefly, and then, sensing that staying abovewater was taking too much of my energy, I took a big breath and went under for a longer haul. It was certainly a lot different playing pinball underwater, not least because there were a lot more bumpers. After a few good smacks, I decided I'd just assume a position that would leave me less vulnerable; I tucked myself into a ball and only made small paddling movements when I could spare the time, to dodge a rock. I couldn't see but very poorly. I surfaced for a breath. I floated atop the water in the ball shape with my eyes closed to protect them, though I couldn't really see because of the water anyhow. I felt myself ram up against several more boulders, and then I felt myself clear and free of all obstacles—just like that. Still—and I now realize how bad an idea this was—I stayed balled up with my eyes closed for another minute or so. I believe I was in shock, to some extent. Then I felt sand under me and opened my eyes to find myself washed up on shore. Upstream were two streams, both full of boulders and with gushing, splashing, ricocheting water. I had no idea which one I had come out of.*